

THE HILL

Episode 1 — “Mulberry Township”

Pilot Script Draft — Act Three

Version 0.1 Continued

ACT THREE

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — MORNING

The next morning is clearer.

That makes it worse.

No fog to soften the ridge.

No mist to hide the road.

The house sits exposed under a pale sky.

Mary Ann hangs cloth on a line.

Each piece snaps once in the wind.

John Samuel carries kindling.

Christopher follows with one stick, proud of himself.

William comes from the tree line with mud on his boots.

Permelia sees the mud.

PERMELIA

You been up there again.

WILLIAM

Not far.

PERMELIA

Men always say “not far” when they know it was.

William wipes his hands on his trousers.

MARY ANN
You see anything?

William looks toward the road above the house.

WILLIAM
Too much open ground between here and there.

That is not an answer.

It is the only one he has.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — MORNING

Spencer sits at the table with the empty place where the auger should be.

A small box of tools sits open.

He looks at it like an insult.

Permelia sets coffee down.

PERMELIA
You planning to stare it back?

SPENCER
He said he'd bring it.

PERMELIA
Men say things.

SPENCER
Jess ain't a thief.

Permelia turns on him.

Not loud.

PERMELIA
I ain't worried he stole your auger.

Spencer looks at her.

He hears it now.

The tool was never the issue.

Mary Ann enters with a bowl.

Stops when she feels the room.

MARY ANN

What?

No one answers.

Christopher appears in the doorway.

CHRISTOPHER

What's an auger?

Spencer closes the box.

SPENCER

A tool.

CHRISTOPHER

For what?

Spencer almost answers.

Then cannot.

WILLIAM

Making holes.

Christopher nods, satisfied.

The adults are not.

EXT. ROAD ABOVE HORNER HOMESTEAD — DAY

Jess Wilson rides with another man.

The second man remains partly obscured. Ordinary hat. Ordinary coat. Ordinary danger.

They stop near the place where the road overlooks the Horner land.

Jess does not point.

He does not need to.

The second man looks down toward the house.

Smoke.

Children.

A woman at the line.

A man near the field.

The second rider spits into the dust.

SECOND RIDER

That him?

Jess watches.

JESS

One of them.

SECOND RIDER

Which?

Jess does not answer immediately.

Below, William crosses the yard.

Then Spencer steps outside.

Jess studies both.

JESS

Depends who you're asking for.

The second rider looks at him.

Jess turns his mule.

JESS (CONT'D)

Come on.

They ride off.

The house remains below, unaware of the exact words.

But not unaware of being watched.

EXT. FIELD EDGE — DAY

William works near the field.

John Samuel brings water.

He holds it up.

William drinks.

JOHN SAMUEL
They watching us?

William lowers the cup.

WILLIAM
Who told you that?

JOHN SAMUEL
Nobody.

WILLIAM
Then why ask?

John Samuel looks toward the ridge.

JOHN SAMUEL
People look different when they're being looked at.

William studies the boy.

That is too sharp for seven.

WILLIAM
You don't say that inside.

JOHN SAMUEL
Why?

WILLIAM
Because grown folks already know it.

JOHN SAMUEL

Then why don't they do something?

William has no clean answer.

He hands back the cup.

WILLIAM

Sometimes knowing comes before doing.

John Samuel takes the cup.

JOHN SAMUEL

How long before?

William looks toward the ridge.

WILLIAM

Too long, mostly.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — DAY

Mary Ann folds cloth.

Permelia sorts dried beans.

The sound is small and steady.

Mary Ann is working too fast.

Permelia notices.

PERMELIA

You'll split the seam.

Mary Ann stops.

MARY ANN

I keep thinking of Martha.

Permelia does not look up.

MARY ANN (CONT'D)

One neighbor.

PERMELIA

I heard it.

MARY ANN

No. I mean —

She searches.

MARY ANN (CONT'D)

How do you keep living beside people if one neighbor can be enough?

Permelia's hands pause over the beans.

PERMELIA

You don't live beside people.

Mary Ann looks at her.

PERMELIA (CONT'D)

You live among what you know and what you don't.

That is not comfort.

It is instruction.

MARY ANN

And which is worse?

Permelia resumes sorting.

PERMELIA

Depends who knows you.

EXT. CLARKSVILLE ROAD / SMALL PUBLIC SPACE — DAY

A small public place near road or store. Could be a mill yard, porch, or courthouse edge depending on production.

Men gather in loose knots.

No one trusts the knots.

A few names drift in fragments.

COMPANY K.

LEWISBURG.

ACORD.

HORNER.

BOEN.

A man folds a paper and tucks it away when another approaches.

A second man laughs too loudly.

A third stops speaking when Jess Wilson passes.

Jess does not stop.

He hears enough by walking.

At the edge of the group, a LOCAL MAN speaks low to another.

LOCAL MAN

Hill won't stir himself over every dead Union man in these hills.

SECOND LOCAL

Keep your voice down.

LOCAL MAN

Why? He don't know it?

The second local looks around.

SECOND LOCAL

Knowing ain't the trouble.

The men go quiet as another rider passes.

The county is learning silence in public.

EXT. MODERN WORKSPACE — DAY

Daniel sits with a county map and a page of notes.

He writes:

PUBLIC SILENCE

Then:

PRIVATE KNOWLEDGE

Beside them:

WHO COULD SPEAK?

WHO COULD NOT?

WHO HAD AUTHORITY?

Daniel's hand rests on the page.

DANIEL (V.O.)

A county does not have to agree on the truth to know what cannot be said in public.

He turns to another paper.

Military file language.

Pension reference.

Cemetery note.

DANIEL (V.O.)

Some silences are fear. Some are loyalty. Some are power. Most are more than one thing.

He underlines:

KNOWN TO HIS FAMILY

DANIEL (V.O.)

That phrase is not only grief. It is an accusation without a courtroom.

Cut back.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — LATE DAY

Spencer is cleaning a rifle.

Not theatrically.

Carefully.

William watches from the doorway.

WILLIAM

You planning on using that?

SPENCER

I'm planning on it working if I need it.

WILLIAM

You won't get time.

Spencer looks up.

SPENCER

You always this cheerful?

WILLIAM

You think they'll knock?

Spencer returns to the rifle.

SPENCER

I think a man who comes to my house will know he's at my house.

WILLIAM

That's what worries me.

A beat.

Spencer stops.

SPENCER

You think I don't see it?

William says nothing.

SPENCER (CONT'D)

You think because I don't jump at every sound, I don't hear it?

WILLIAM

I think you hear it and keep hoping it still means what it used to mean.

That lands.

Spencer's face hardens.

SPENCER

You watch your mouth.

WILLIAM

I watch the road.

Silence.

Neither man wins.

EXT. HORNER YARD — DUSK

Christopher chases a chicken.

For a moment, he is only four.

The bird darts under a wagon.

Christopher laughs.

The sound is strange in the episode because it is almost normal.

John Samuel sees William watching the road.

He stops smiling before Christopher does.

Mary Ann calls from the doorway.

MARY ANN

Christopher. Leave it be.

Christopher ignores her.

The chicken runs toward the open yard.

John Samuel rushes after Christopher and grabs his sleeve.

Too hard.

Christopher yelps.

CHRISTOPHER

Ow.

JOHN SAMUEL

Don't go out there.

MARY ANN
John Samuel.

John Samuel releases him.

He looks ashamed.

Then angry because shame is easier than fear.

JOHN SAMUEL
He was going too far.

Mary Ann sees his face.

She does not scold him.

MARY ANN
Bring him in.

John Samuel takes Christopher's hand.

This time Christopher does not fight.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — DUSK

Mary Ann kneels before John Samuel.

Christopher sits nearby, holding the chicken feather he managed to grab.

MARY ANN
You don't pull him like that.

JOHN SAMUEL
He don't listen.

MARY ANN
He's little.

JOHN SAMUEL
So was I.

Mary Ann has no answer.

That line does damage.

Permelia hears it from across the room.

She turns away before anyone sees her face.

EXT. TREE LINE — SAME

Lewis Cass Horner crouches near the edge of timber.

He watches the road.

He has not left as far as the family thought.

Or he circled back.

Below, the Horner house glows with lamplight.

Above, the road is darker.

He hears riders somewhere beyond the ridge.

Not close.

Not far enough.

Lewis lowers himself behind brush.

Listens.

Two voices, distant.

Unclear.

One laugh.

A horse snorts.

Then the sounds move away.

Lewis exhales quietly.

He looks toward the house.

He wants to go down.

He does not.

Going down would show where he is.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

Supper.

Not the chicken dinner yet.

A smaller meal.

Beans.

Cornbread.

Water.

The family eats because bodies require it.

Spencer sits at one end.

Permelia at the other.

William near the door.

Mary Ann with the boys.

The empty place where a tool should be is not visible, but the absence is present.

SPENCER

Tomorrow I'll go by Jess's.

William looks up.

WILLIAM

No.

Spencer's eyes harden.

SPENCER

No?

WILLIAM

You don't walk into a man's yard asking for what he didn't bring back.

SPENCER

It's my auger.

WILLIAM

It ain't about the auger.

Spencer's hand tightens around his cup.

PERMELIA

Enough.

SPENCER

No. Let him say it.

William looks at Spencer.

WILLIAM

You go there, you tell him you noticed.

SPENCER

I did notice.

WILLIAM

Then he knows you know.

MARY ANN

Stop.

Her voice is low, but it cuts.

Everyone looks at her.

MARY ANN (CONT'D)

The boys are eating.

John Samuel is not eating.

He is listening.

Christopher is eating with the seriousness of someone trying not to get noticed.

Spencer sees them.

The anger drains into shame.

He looks down.

SPENCER

Eat.

No one does for a beat.

Then Permelia lifts her spoon.

The others follow.

A family pretending a meal can hold them together.

EXT. MODERN WORKSPACE — NIGHT

Daniel has the map open under a desk lamp.

Only a pool of light.

The rest of the room dark.

He places small marks:

HOMESTEAD
CREEK
RIDGE ROAD
FIELD
CAVE AREA
CEMETERY

He studies the space between them.

DANIEL (V.O.)

Distance looks different on paper.

His pencil hovers over the ridge road.

DANIEL (V.O.)

A quarter mile can look small until it is between a child and a house. Between a field and timber. Between a man and the place he almost reaches.

He marks the road again.

DANIEL (V.O.)

The land did not cause the violence.

A beat.

DANIEL (V.O.)

But it gave violence a way to arrive unseen.

Cut back.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — NIGHT

The house.

The ridge.

The road.

The creek below.

The sound of water.

Then another sound.

A horse.

Maybe.

The house does not move.

But inside it, people are awake.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

John Samuel lies awake.

Christopher sleeps beside him.

William sits in a chair near the door, eyes open.

Mary Ann dozes upright, sewing in her lap.

Permelia stands at the hearth, not doing anything now.

Spencer is awake too, though his eyes are closed.

No one says they are afraid.

Everyone is.

EXT. ROAD ABOVE HOMESTEAD — NIGHT

A shadow moves along the ridge road.

Then another.

Not close enough to attack.

Close enough to know the road.

A low voice.

Unintelligible.

The camera stays back.

No reveal.

No threat music.

Just presence.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

John Samuel's eyes shift toward the door.

William's hand moves slowly toward the rifle.

Permelia sees.

Mary Ann wakes fully.

Spencer opens his eyes.

No one speaks.

The sounds outside fade.

Maybe passing.

Maybe watching.

The family remains still long after the sound is gone.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — DAWN

First light.

The house survived the night.

That should feel like relief.

It does not.

The ridge is still there.

The road is still there.

The tool is still missing.

The family has one less day before the world breaks.

CUT TO BLACK.

END OF ACT THREE.